

FORBIDDEN PATTERNS

This document defines what makes writing sound like AI. It is mostly about STATISTICAL PATTERNS, not individual words. Check every draft against the pattern rules first. The short word list at the end is a secondary check.

PART 1 — SENTENCE-LENGTH PATTERNS (most important)

AI writing clusters sentence lengths in a narrow band. Human writing swings.

RULES:

- No run of 3+ consecutive sentences whose lengths are within ~5 words of each other. Break the pattern.
- Every paragraph must contain real range: at least one short sentence (under 8 words) AND at least one long sentence (over 25 words), unless the paragraph is only 1–2 sentences.
- Do not let average sentence length sit flat across the whole piece. Some paragraphs should run long and dense; others should be short and clipped.
- A one-word or two-word sentence is allowed and encouraged occasionally.

FAIL SIGNAL: If you read the draft and every sentence "feels" the same length, it fails. Rewrite for swing.

PART 2 — STRUCTURAL REPETITION PATTERNS

AI reuses the same shapes. Humans vary them.

RULES:

- Sentence openings: within any paragraph, do not start more than 2

sentences the same way (same first word, or same subject-verb-object shape). Vary openers — questions, fragments, subordinate clauses, mid-thought starts.

- Paragraph openings: consecutive paragraphs must not open with the same template (e.g. every paragraph starting "First... Next... Finally," or "Let's talk about X").
- Lists: avoid the reflexive three-item parallel list. If three items genuinely belong together, fine — but do not make balanced triples a habit. Break them into prose, vary the count, or expand one item instead.
- Do not give every paragraph the same internal shape (claim → because → restate). Mix it up: some paragraphs argue, some show an example, some ask, some just land a single line.

PART 3 — SPECIFICITY / PREDICTABILITY PATTERNS

AI text is predictable because it stays generic. Specific writing is less predictable — that's what makes it read as human.

RULES:

- Flag any sentence that could appear, unchanged, in an article on a totally different topic. Generic filler = fail. Replace with a concrete detail, number, name, or example.
- Avoid empty quantifiers: "many," "a lot of," "various," "several," "a variety of," "numerous" with no actual specifics attached.
- Prefer the concrete noun over the abstract one. Prefer the real example over the category.
- Every paragraph should carry at least one specific, non-interchangeable detail. If it carries none, it's probably AI-shaped.

PART 4 — HEDGING & SMOOTHNESS PATTERNS

AI over-hedges and over-smooths. Humans commit and leave edges.

RULES:

- Cut throat-clearing openers that delay the point ("It's important to note that," "When it comes to," "In today's world"). Start with the actual point.
- Don't qualify every claim into mush. Some sentences should state things plainly and directly.
- Allow controlled imperfection: an occasional fragment, an aside, a blunt short line, a direct address to the reader. Perfect smoothness is itself an AI tell.
- Vary tone within the piece. AI holds one even register the whole way through; humans shift — a sharp line here, a slower explanation there.

PART 5 — SECONDARY CHECK: OVERUSED WORDS

Treat this as a small secondary scan, NOT the main rule. These words are statistically overrepresented in AI text. Their presence is a hint to check the sentence, not an automatic ban — if a word is genuinely the most accurate one, keep it. Watch especially for CLUSTERS of these appearing together, which is the real tell:

delve, tapestry, realm, landscape (figurative), navigate (figurative), embark, unlock, elevate, empower, seamless, leverage (verb), foster, harness, robust, testament, "not only... but also," "isn't just X, it's Y," "let's dive in."

The point is not to ban words. It's to catch the STATISTICAL SHAPE: narrow sentence-length range, repeated structures, generic filler, and over-smoothing. Fix those and the word choices usually follow.

@tooldrop